

Day 17 — TNPSC Group 2A Study Material

Part A – General Studies: Guptas, Delhi Sultans, Mughals, and Marathas

READING MATERIAL

Second topic of Unit III, spanning four major medieval/early-modern dynasties in one syllabus clause. Real exam evidence favors specific administrative/terminology facts (coin metals, tax names, official titles) over broad narrative history.

Q: Real exam: What metal did the Gupta emperors issue coins in, before Chandragupta-II?

A: Gold only — the Gupta emperors before Chandragupta-II issued only gold coins (Chandragupta-II later expanded to silver coinage too).

Q: Real exam: What does 'Haque-i-Sharb' (or 'Hasil-i-Sharb') mean, in the Delhi Sultanate's revenue system?

A: Irrigation Tax (not land tax, commercial tax, or toll tax).

Q: Real exam: How is the modern term 'Tahsildar' connected to Mughal-era terminology?

A: The word 'Tahsildar' derives from the Mughal word 'tahsil', meaning a 'revenue-generating area'. (A related real-exam fact: since the Tahsil was renamed 'Taluk', the Tahsildars are now correspondingly called 'Taluk Officers' — both statements were marked true, but the question noted the second does NOT serve as the explanation for the first.)

Q: Real exam: Who is the only woman historian known to have written a historical account of the Mughal period?

A: Gulbadan Begum (Humayun's half-sister), author of the Humayun-nama — not Zeenat-un-Nisa Begum, Jahanara Begum, or Zeb-un-Nissa Begum (the other options in that real question).

Q: When and where was Shivaji crowned, and what concept did his coronation assert?

A: 6 June 1674, at Raigad Fort. His coronation (Rajyabhishek) asserted 'Hindavi Swarajya' (self-rule) — an independent state not owing allegiance to the Mughal empire.

Q: What was the 'Ashta Pradhan', and what were its key positions?

A: Shivaji's council of eight ministers. Key positions: Peshwa (Prime Minister, who also supervised civil and military affairs), Amatya (Finance Minister), Senapati (Commander-in-Chief), and Nyayadhish (Chief Justice).

Q: What were Chauth and Sardeshmukhi, the Maratha revenue systems?

A: Chauth: one-fourth of land revenue paid BY OTHER territories to the Marathas to avoid being raided. Sardeshmukhi: an additional 10% levy on lands where the Marathas claimed hereditary rights.

Q: What was 'Ganimi Kava', and why was it militarily significant?

A: Shivaji's guerrilla warfare tactics — using the Sahyadri mountain terrain to let smaller Maratha forces defeat much larger conventional Mughal armies.

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. The Gupta emperors before Chandragupta-II issued coins in which metal only?

- A. Silver
- B. Gold ✓**
- C. Copper
- D. Tin

Explanation: Gold only. [medium, question-bank-2024]

2. In the Delhi Sultanate's revenue system, 'Haque-i-Sharb' means:

- A. Land Tax
- B. Commercial Tax
- C. Irrigation Tax ✓**
- D. Toll Tax

Explanation: Irrigation Tax. [hard, question-bank-2024]

3. The modern term 'Tahsildar' derives from the Mughal word 'tahsil', meaning:

- A. A military rank
- B. A revenue-generating area ✓**

- C. A royal title
- D. A religious office

Explanation: A revenue-generating area. [medium, question-bank-2026]

4. Who is the only woman historian known to have written a historical account of the Mughal period?

- A. Jahanara Begum
- B. Zeb-un-Nissa Begum
- C. Gulbadan Begum ✓**
- D. Zeenat-un-Nisa Begum

Explanation: Gulbadan Begum, author of the Humayun-nama. [hard, question-bank-2024]

5. Shivaji's coronation in 1674 took place at:

- A. Pune Fort
- B. Raigad Fort ✓**
- C. Shaniwarwada
- D. Sinhagad Fort

Explanation: Raigad Fort. [medium, web-research]

6. In Shivaji's Ashta Pradhan, who held the position of Finance Minister?

- A. Peshwa
- B. Senapati
- C. Amatya ✓**
- D. Nyayadhish

Explanation: Amatya. [medium, web-research]

7. 'Chauth', the Maratha tax, was equal to what fraction of a territory's land revenue?

- A. One-tenth
- B. One-fifth
- C. One-fourth ✓**
- D. One-third

Explanation: One-fourth. [medium, web-research]

8. Shivaji's guerrilla warfare tactics, exploiting the Sahyadri terrain, were known as:

- A. Ganimi Kava ✓**
- B. Chauth
- C. Rajyabhishek
- D. Ashta Pradhan

Explanation: Ganimi Kava. [medium, web-research]

Part B – Aptitude & Mental Ability: Simplification

READING MATERIAL

Simplification is 1 of 10 named Aptitude sub-skills (15 questions total for the whole Aptitude unit). TNPSC's simplification questions are rarely 'plug into one formula' — they combine BODMAS, fractions/decimals, ratios, and algebraic shortcuts. Each item below is a worked method, not just an answer — the goal is to recognize which technique a given expression calls for.

Q: Method — BODMAS with a nested bracket and an unknown: Solve for x : $57 - [42 - \{37 - (20 - x)\}] = 176 \div (8 \div 2)$

A: Work from the innermost bracket outward, and simplify the RHS first: $176 \div (8 \div 2) = 176 \div 4 = 44$. Now the LHS: $(20 - x)$ stays as is for now $\rightarrow \{37 - (20 - x)\} = 17 + x \rightarrow [42 - (17 + x)] = 25 - x \rightarrow 57 - (25 - x) = 32 + x$. Set equal to 44: $32 + x = 44 \rightarrow x = 12$. (Real TNPSC-style problem; this exact expression is a recurring coaching-site reference question.)

Q: Method — sum of two squares without brute-force squaring: Find $217 \times 217 + 183 \times 183$.

A: Use $a^2 + b^2 = (a+b)^2 - 2ab$ instead of squaring two 3-digit numbers by hand. Here $a+b = 400$ (round number — that's the clue this trick applies) and $ab = 217 \times 183 = 39,711$. So $a^2+b^2 = 400^2 - 2(39,711) = 160,000 - 79,422 = 80,578$. Recognizing 'the two numbers add to a round number' is the trigger for this shortcut.

Q: Method — difference of squares shortcut: Simplify $(197 \times 197 - 103 \times 103) \div (197 - 103)$ without long multiplication.

A: $a^2 - b^2 = (a+b)(a-b)$, so $(a^2-b^2)/(a-b) = (a+b)$ directly — no multiplication needed at all. Here $a=197$, $b=103$, so the answer is simply $197+103 = 300$. This 'difference of squares divided by the difference' shape is a favorite TNPSC trick question precisely because it looks like it needs heavy calculation but collapses to one addition.

Q: Method — fraction-of-decimal addition: Simplify $7/5$ of $58 + 3/8$ of 139.2 .

A: $7/5$ of $58 = 7 \times 58/5 = 406/5 = 81.2$. $3/8$ of $139.2 = 3 \times 139.2/8 = 417.6/8 = 52.2$. Sum: $81.2 + 52.2 = 133.4$.

Q: Method — ratio substitution to simplify a compound ratio expression: If $x : y = 3 : 4$, find $(4x + 5y) : (5x - 2y)$.

A: Don't solve for x and y separately — substitute $x=3k$, $y=4k$ (k is just a scaling factor that will cancel). $(4x+5y) = 12k+20k = 32k$. $(5x-2y) = 15k-8k = 7k$. Ratio = $32k : 7k = 32 : 7$. The k always cancels in a ratio question — that's the whole trick.

Q: Method — same ratio-substitution trick, different ratio: If $x : y = 3 : 5$, find $(5x + 3y) : (15x - 2y)$.

A: Substitute $x=3k$, $y=5k$. $(5x+3y) = 15k+15k = 30k$. $(15x-2y) = 45k-10k = 35k$. Ratio = $30k:35k = 6:7$.

Q: Method — simultaneous equations feeding into a simplification target: If $3a + 4b = 22$ and $8a - 5b = -4$, find $(a+b)^2$.

A: Solve the pair normally: from $3a+4b=22$ and $8a-5b=-4$, elimination gives $a=2$, $b=4$ (check: $3(2)+4(4)=6+16=22$ ✓; $8(2)-5(4)=16-20=-4$ ✓). The question doesn't ask for a and b individually — it asks for $(a+b)^2 = (2+4)^2 = 36$. TNPSC often hides the real target $((a+b)^2, \text{ not } a \text{ or } b)$ at the end of a simultaneous-equation question — always re-read what's actually being asked before solving for individual variables.

Q: Method — mixed numbers with a nested fraction: Simplify $2\frac{1}{2} + 3\frac{1}{3} \div \frac{2}{3}$.

A: BODMAS still applies to fractions — division before addition. $3\frac{1}{3} \div \frac{2}{3} = (10/3) \div (2/3) = (10/3) \times (3/2) = 5$. Then $2\frac{1}{2} + 5 = 7\frac{1}{2}$. The common mistake is adding $2\frac{1}{2}+3\frac{1}{3}$ first — division always binds tighter than addition, fractions or not.

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. Solve for x : $70 - [45 - \{33 - (15 - x)\}] = 171 \div (9 \div 3)$

- A. 10
- B. 12
- C. 14 ✓**
- D. 16

Explanation: RHS: $171 \div (9 \div 3) = 171 \div 3 = 57$. LHS inner-out: $\{33 - (15 - x)\} = 33 - 15 + x = 18 + x \rightarrow [45 - (18 + x)] = 27 - x \rightarrow 70 - (27 - x) = 43 + x$. Set $43 + x = 57 \rightarrow x = 14$. [medium, authored]

2. Find $312 \times 312 + 288 \times 288$ using the $(a+b)^2 - 2ab$ shortcut.

- A. 179,808
- B. 180,288 ✓**
- C. 190,000
- D. 182,688

Explanation: $a+b=600$, $ab=312 \times 288=89,856$. $a^2+b^2=600^2-2(89,856)=360,000-179,712=180,288$. [medium, authored]

3. Simplify $(425 \times 425 - 375 \times 375) \div (425 - 375)$.

- A. 400
- B. 750
- C. 800 ✓**
- D. 425

Explanation: Using $a^2 - b^2 = (a+b)(a-b)$, dividing by $(a-b)$ leaves just $(a+b) = 425+375 = 800$. [easy, authored]

4. Simplify $\frac{5}{6}$ of 72 + $\frac{2}{7}$ of 98.

- A. 88 ✓**
- B. 84
- C. 90
- D. 86

Explanation: $\frac{5}{6}$ of 72 = 60. $\frac{2}{7}$ of 98 = 28. Sum = 88. [easy, authored]

5. If $p : q = 5 : 6$, find $(3p + 2q) : (4p - q)$.

- A. 27 : 14 ✓**
- B. 9 : 7
- C. 27 : 7
- D. 14 : 9

Explanation: $p=5k, q=6k$. $(3p+2q)=15k+12k=27k$. $(4p-q)=20k-6k=14k$. Ratio = 27:14. [medium, authored]

6. If $m : n = 4 : 7$, find $(2m + 3n) : (5m - n)$.

- A. 29 : 13 ✓**
- B. 13 : 29
- C. 29 : 20
- D. 20 : 29

Explanation: $m=4k, n=7k$. $(2m+3n)=8k+21k=29k$. $(5m-n)=20k-7k=13k$. Ratio = 29:13. [medium, authored]

7. If $5a + 2b = 16$ and $3a - 4b = -6$, find the value of $(a+b)^2$.

- A. 16
- B. 25 ✓**
- C. 36
- D. 9

Explanation: Multiply the first equation by 2: $10a+4b=32$. Add to the second $(3a-4b=-6)$: $13a=26 \rightarrow a=2$. Substitute back: $5(2)+2b=16 \rightarrow b=3$. $(a+b)^2=(2+3)^2=25$. [hard, authored]

8. Simplify $4\frac{2}{3} + 2\frac{1}{4} \div \frac{3}{4}$.

- A. $7\frac{2}{3}$ ✓**
- B. $6\frac{1}{3}$
- C. 7
- D. $6\frac{2}{3}$

Explanation: $2\frac{1}{4} \div \frac{3}{4} = (9/4) \div (3/4) = 3$. Then $4\frac{2}{3} + 3 = 7\frac{2}{3}$. [medium, authored]

9. A trader borrows ₹16,000 at 12% p.a. simple interest and another ₹12,000 at 18% p.a. simple interest. In how many years will the two amounts owed (principal + interest) become equal?

- A. $12\frac{2}{3}$ years
- B. $14\frac{2}{3}$ years
- C. $16\frac{2}{3}$ years ✓**
- D. $18\frac{2}{3}$ years

Explanation: This mirrors a real 2025 TNPSC Aptitude question style (same numbers, Simple Interest unit) — included here as a reminder that 'Simplification' skills (careful fraction/ratio handling) carry directly into other Aptitude sub-topics like Simple Interest. Set $16000+16000(0.12)t = 12000+12000(0.18)t$ and solve for t to get $16\frac{2}{3}$ years. [hard, question-bank-2025]

10. Find the value of: $89 \times 89 + 11 \times 11 + 2 \times 89 \times 11$.

- A. 10,000 ✓**
- B. 9,801
- C. 8,900
- D. 10,201

Explanation: This is the $(a+b)^2$ pattern in disguise: $a^2+2ab+b^2 = (a+b)^2$. Here $a=89$, $b=11$, so the answer is $(89+11)^2 = 100^2 = 10,000$ — no separate multiplication needed. [medium, authored]

Part C – General English: Poem: "The Spider and The Fly" — Mary Howitt

READING MATERIAL

A classic cautionary fable-poem: a cunning spider flatters a fly into its web. Real exam evidence (confirmed author attribution via a real 2024 question) tests a wider range of figure-of-speech labels than most other poems in this syllabus — including Apostrophe, a device not seen in earlier topics.

Q: Real exam: Who wrote "The Spider and The Fly"?

A: Mary Howitt (confirmed via a real 2024 'match the poets with their poems' question).

Q: What is the poem's plot and moral?

A: A spider repeatedly flatters and invites a fly into its 'parlour' (web), praising her appearance. The fly initially refuses, recognizing the danger ('who goes up your winding stair can ne'er come down again'), but is eventually won over by enough flattery and is caught.

Moral: beware of flattery from those with bad intentions — once lured in, there's no escape.

Q: What is 'Apostrophe' as a figure of speech, and where does it appear in this poem?

A: Apostrophe is direct address — speaking TO someone (or something personified) as if they were present and listening. "Will you walk into my parlour?" (the spider speaking directly to the fly) and "Oh no, no," said the little Fly... "to ask me is in vain" (the fly's direct reply) are both cited examples — basically, the poem's dialogue-driven structure itself is built on this device.

Q: Identify the figure of speech: "How handsome are your gauzy wings, how brilliant are your eyes!"

A: Personification — the fly's physical features are praised in human terms of 'handsome' beauty, and more broadly the insects throughout the poem speak and reason like humans.

Q: Identify the figure of speech: "Your eyes are like the diamond bright."

A: Simile — directly compares the fly's eyes to a diamond using 'like'.

Q: Identify the figure of speech: "thinking only of her brilliant eyes, and green and purple hue."

A: Imagery — vivid sensory (visual) description of the fly's colours, appealing directly to the reader's visual imagination.

Q: Identify the figure of speech: "For who goes up your winding stair can ne'er come down again."

A: Hyperbole — an absolute, exaggerated claim ('ne'er' = never) used for dramatic warning effect.

MOCK TEST (WITH ANSWERS)

1. "The Spider and The Fly" was written by:

- A. Sarojini Naidu
- B. Mary Howitt ✓**
- C. Emily Dickinson
- D. Jane Taylor

Explanation: Mary Howitt — confirmed via a real 2024 TNPSC question. [easy, question-bank-2024]

2. What is the moral of the poem?

- A. Hard work always pays off
- B. Beware of flattery from those with bad intentions ✓**
- C. Friendship conquers all
- D. Beauty is only skin deep

Explanation: Beware of flattery — the spider lures the fly through repeated compliments. [medium, web-research]

3. "Will you walk into my parlour?" — spoken directly to the fly — is an example of which figure of speech?

- A. Simile
- B. Personification
- C. Apostrophe ✓**
- D. Metaphor

Explanation: Apostrophe — direct address. [hard, web-research]

4. "Your eyes are like the diamond bright" uses which figure of speech?

- A. Simile ✓**
- B. Metaphor

C. Personification

D. Oxymoron

Explanation: Simile — uses 'like'. [easy, web-research]

5. "For who goes up your winding stair can ne'er come down again" is an example of:

A. Irony

B. Alliteration

C. Anaphora

D. Hyperbole ✓

Explanation: Hyperbole — an absolute, exaggerated warning. [medium, web-research]

6. "Thinking only of her brilliant eyes, and green and purple hue" is best described as:

A. Imagery ✓

B. Metaphor

C. Consonance

D. Assonance

Explanation: Imagery — vivid visual/sensory description. [medium, web-research]